

Brief 2 — QS Tools / TSC Meeting Question Framework

David Reid Meeting — Bullet Question Alignment

Purpose

This brief frames the key questions Paul wanted answered during the meeting with David Reid and aligns them with the meeting outcomes.

The aim was to test whether the thinking behind TSC's business strategy and QS Tools' recovery model made sense to someone with practical experience in business recovery, operations, productivity, and advisory work.

1. TSC Business Questions

Question 1 — What would you look at first when assessing whether a struggling business is worth saving?

Meeting outcome

David looked first at the P&L.

He focused on:

- sales
- material cost
- fixed costs
- labour structure
- scalability
- productivity
- whether there is a mechanism to improve

Key learning

The P&L must remain the primary diagnostic anchor.

This is true for both TSC and QS Tools.

Question 2 — Is TSC's current problem caused by the business model, the market, or a specific cashflow shock?

Meeting outcome

The discussion separated several issues:

- the market has dropped
- competitors are pricing aggressively
- a major failed/problem job has damaged cashflow
- TSC has reduced overhead and staff
- the business may still have an underlying profit engine if suitable work returns

Key learning

TSC needs to separate:

- cashflow damage
- market pressure
- pricing pressure
- business structure
- underlying profitability

This supports QS Tools' future diagnostic direction: identify whether the problem is market, cost, pricing, revenue, structure, or execution.

Question 3 — What is the real macro driver of TSC's business?

Meeting outcome

The discussion identified that TSC's real macro driver may be:

cubic metres of concrete installed/sold

Concrete volume drives:

- material spend
- revenue
- labour utilisation
- supplier pricing power
- margin opportunity

Key learning

TSC should track the operational driver behind revenue, not just total revenue.

For TSC, this is likely concrete volume.

Question 4 — What type of work should TSC target?

Meeting outcome

Simple high-volume work is difficult because large competitors have buying power and scale.

TSC may be more defensible in:

- complex work
- high-end homes
- specialist slab/foundation work
- difficult sites
- technically demanding jobs

Key learning

TSC should avoid commodity competition where possible and lean into specialist technical work.

Question 5 — What are the realistic strategic options for TSC?

Meeting outcome

David framed the options as:

1. push through
2. shrink to low overhead
3. hybrid model
4. differentiate
5. park or exit

Key learning

TSC needs a deliberate 12-month plan rather than reactive decisions based only on current cashflow pain.

2. QS Tools Validation Questions

Question 6 — Do small trade/construction businesses actually understand their true labour cost?

Meeting outcome

This was strongly validated.

David recognised that many businesses do not properly understand labour cost or true recoverable hourly rate.

Key learning

The labour recovery module remains a strong foundation.

Simple front-end message:

Your true labour cost is X.
Your minimum recoverable labour rate is Y.
You are above/below recovery by Z.

Question 7 — Do existing job management tools already solve this?

Meeting outcome

David challenged this directly.

The distinction became:

- job tools manage jobs
- QS Tools checks whether the business model works

Key learning

Positioning:

Job tools manage the work.
QS Tools checks whether the business behind the work is viable.

Or:

Job tools tell you what happened.
QS Tools tells you whether what happened actually works.

Question 8 — Should QS Tools integrate with Xero?

Meeting outcome

Yes, but the order matters.

David saw Xero as the trusted data source.

The first useful integration is:

Xero P&L → QS Tools

Longer term:

quote → work orders → purchase orders → reconciliation → Xero

Key learning

Near-term priority:

1. simple dashboard
2. P&L import from Xero
3. baseline versus actual comparison

Long-term possibility:

1. quote input
 2. work orders
 3. purchase orders
 4. reconciliation
 5. invoice/write-back flow
-

Question 9 — Can AI replace this?

Meeting outcome

David raised this as a serious challenge.

The conclusion was that AI can analyse and simplify information, but only if the correct data structure already exists.

Key learning

QS Tools should not fight AI.

Positioning:

QS Tools is the structured business engine.
AI can sit on top as the explanation and insight layer.

Question 10 — Is QS Tools too complex?

Meeting outcome

Yes, in its current presentation.

David engaged with the tool and drilled into parts of it, but the first impression is still too heavy.

Key learning

The system does not need to be simplified.

The output needs to be simplified.

The first screen should answer:

1. Are you making money properly?
2. What is leaking?
3. What should you fix first?

Everything else should be drilldown.

Question 11 — What would someone need to see before recommending it?

Meeting outcome

This was not asked directly, but the answer became clear.

A recommender would need to see:

- simple dashboard
- clear P&L connection
- baseline versus actual graph
- labour/material/overhead leakage
- simple KPI outputs
- traceable numbers
- clear target user
- simple onboarding path

Key learning

A single trend line is not enough.

The user needs:

expected performance versus actual performance

The dashboard should show:

- baseline
 - actual
 - variance
 - direction of travel
 - cause of drift
-

3. Product Direction Confirmed by the Questions

Confirmed

The meeting confirmed that QS Tools is solving a real problem:

- small businesses do not understand cost versus price
- labour recovery is poorly understood
- many owners cannot interpret their P&L properly
- job-level tools do not give a macro business recovery view
- Xero is trusted but often not structured for decision-making
- the system needs to reconcile back to real accounting data

Not fully confirmed

The meeting did not fully confirm:

- who will pay first
- whether the first buyer is the owner, accountant, advisor, or mentor
- whether the product should start as software-only or assisted setup
- whether the full job-management loop should be built now or later

Strongest risk

The strongest risk is not the model.

The strongest risk is usability.

If the tool feels complex, the users who need it most may not adopt it.

4. Immediate Build Priorities

Priority 1 — Build the answer-first dashboard

The first screen should show:

1. Are you making money properly?
2. What is leaking?
3. What should you fix first?
4. Are you tracking above or below baseline?
5. Is the issue labour, materials, overhead, assets, pricing, revenue, or structure?

Priority 2 — Build baseline versus actual graph

The graph should compare:

- expected performance
- actual performance
- monthly drift
- cumulative direction

This answers:

Is the business going up or down compared with where it should be?

Priority 3 — Xero/P&L import

Start with:

Xero P&L → QS Tools

Priority 4 — Simple labour KPI

The simplest sellable KPI may be:

Your true labour recovery rate.

Priority 5 — Keep the monster hidden

The underlying system can stay complex because it is required to produce accurate answers.

The user should first see only:

- the result
- the reason
- the next action

Final Brief Summary

The meeting questions successfully tested the right areas.

For TSC, the discussion clarified that the current issue is a mix of market pressure, cashflow shock, workload shortage, and strategic positioning.

For QS Tools, the discussion validated the core problem and model. The strongest confirmed needs are labour recovery, cost versus price clarity, P&L anchoring, and baseline versus actual tracking.

The next phase should not add more visible complexity.

The next phase should turn the existing system into a simple dashboard that tells the user:

This is where your business should be.

This is where it actually is.

This is the gap.

This is what is causing it.

This is what to fix first.